What is it?

The sub-tropical ridge runs across a belt of high pressure that encircles the globe in the middle latitudes. It is part of the global circulation of the atmosphere.

The position of the sub-tropical ridge plays an important part in the way the weather in Australia varies from season to season.

During the warmer half of the year in southern Australia (November to April), the sub-tropical ridge is generally located to the south of the continent. High pressure systems (also called anticyclones), which are associated with stable and dry conditions, generally move eastwards along the ridge.

In autumn, the sub-tropical ridge moves northward and remains over the Australian continent for most of the colder half of the year in southern Australia (May to October). Conditions along the ridge, under the influence of the high pressure systems dry and descending air, tend to be stable and drier.

71. The strength of the Trade Winds has an effect upon the rainfall across northern Australia.

What are they?

The Trade Winds are the east to southeasterly winds which blow across much of the southern hemisphere tropics, affecting tropical to subtropical areas of Australia.

The Trade Winds affect much of northern and parts of eastern Australia. They collect moisture as they move eastward over the tropical Pacific Ocean towards the east coast of Australia and are associated with enhanced rainfall to tropical and sub-tropical areas of the east coast.

The Trade Winds are strongest during the winter months (dry season in the tropics). During this time, when the Australian monsoon has receded to the northern hemisphere, the Trade Winds blow east/ southeastward across the continent, drying out as they move over inland northern Australia and the top end. At this time of the year, the Trade Winds bring more stable (drier) conditions to these areas of the country.

The Trade Winds blow all year round as they are a part of the general circulation of the atmosphere. However, they are strongest in the winter months when they have the greatest affect on